

Investigating the Influence of Right-Wing Populism and Economic Conditions on Climate Change Perception

Research Proposal

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Abstract

Right Wing Populist (RWP) movements have resurged in many Western democracies, reshaping political landscapes, and challenging established norms. Studies show that supporters of RWP are frequently more skeptical towards climate change and less supportive of climate policies. However, there appears to be limited empirical evidence of a causal link between RWP parties and climate skepticism. Literature addressing the reasons individuals supporting RWP parties tend to be more skeptical about climate change has presented competing explanations. Proponents of the structuralist theory contend that changes in the structure of the global economy have resulted in job loss, rising inequality, and stagnant wages, thereby contributing to the simultaneous ascent of RWP and the displacement of climate concern by more acutely felt economic anxieties. By contrast, an alternative view links the ideological content of RWP to the spread of climate skepticism and opposition to climate policies, as right-wing political elites frame the climate agenda as a liberal, cosmopolitan issue that is in opposition to nationalist interests.

This paper seeks to address whether aligning with RWP parties influences an individual's climate change concern. It breaks new ground by undertaking an extensive empirical, causal analysis of the structuralist theory. I combine survey data on over 74,000 individuals from 23 European countries with a wide range of regional and individual political and economic variables that have been overlooked in previous research. State-of-the art machine learning methods enable an assessment of how the impact of RWP parties varies among individuals across distinct regions, ideological convictions, and economic conditions. Understanding the mechanisms that influence an individual's stance on climate change is of vital importance to overcome political backlash against environmental policies.

1 Introduction

Over the past decade, Right Wing Populist (RWP) movements have resurged in many Western democracies, reshaping political landscapes, and challenging established norms. Studies show that supporters of RWP are frequently more skeptical towards climate change and less supportive of climate policies (McCright et al. 2016). Whilst these findings remain consistent across the US and many Western European countries, there appears to be limited empirical evidence for a causal link between RWP parties and climate skepticism (Lockwood, 2018). Climate skepticism is at the source of two phenomena which threaten the implementation of stringent climate policy: increasing political polarization of climate change in Europe (Hoffarth et al 2016) and surging political backlash against environmental policies (Patterson 2023), see for instance the Gilets Jaunes in France and the recent farmers protests in Germany. Taken together, RWP movements and broadened climate skepticism are the “revenge of the places that don’t matter” (Rodríguez-Pose 2018), triggered by a geography of discontent across Europe (Dijkstra 2020).

Diverging theories explain why individuals that endorse RWP parties tend to be more climate skeptic (Lockwood, 2018). Proponents of the ‘structuralist’ theory contend that changes in the global economy’s structure resulting in job loss, rising inequality, and stagnant wages have not only contributed to the ascent of RWP but have also resulted in diminished climate concern, as materialist worries intensify among a wide segment of the population. Indeed, a vast body of literature shows that structural economic conditions, such as inequality (Hufe et al., 2022), globalization (Autor et al., 2020), immigration (Dinas et al., 2019), social mobility (Protzer, 2021), unemployment (Bergh & Kärnä, 2021) as well as levels of social spending (Foster & Frieden; 2020), are potential drivers behind the support of RWP parties. At the same time, the literature has established a robust link between economic conditions and climate change attitudes at the individual (Duijndam & van Beukering, 2020; Kenny, 2019; Scruggs & Benegal, 2012) and regional level (Bez et al 2023). As the prevailing narrative links environmental protection to worsening economic conditions (Vona 2019), people adjust their expressed views on climate change when they clash with individual economic security with respect to income and employment (Scruggs & Benegal, 2012). The economic situation of individuals influences their level of concern about climate change (Duijndam & van Beukering, 2020) because economic issues often outweigh climate change concerns, given their immediate effects on individual well-being (Capstick et al., 2015; van der Linden, 2017).

At the same time, the ideological content of RWP has also been linked to the spread of climate skepticism and opposition to climate policies (Kulin et al., 2021; Huber, 2020). The complex and cosmopolitan nature of climate (negotiations), along with elite-driven top-down rhetoric, makes it easy for populists to frame the issue as a divide between the elite and the people (Huber, 2020). Additionally, RWP movements continue to depict the climate agenda as a liberal, cosmopolitan elite issue which is in opposition to nationalist interests (Forchtner 2019). Most right-wing populist parties in Europe tend to express skepticism towards climate change, about the trend, attribution, or the impact of climate change (Duijndam & van Beukering, 2020). Although these parties may not prioritize climate issues, their skeptical stance on climate change is likely to impact their supporters, given the tendency of the mass to follow rather than lead public opinion (Lenz, 2012).

2 Research Questions

The primary research question that this paper seeks to address is whether aligning with RWP parties influences an individual’s climate change concern. To infer whether climate change concern is driven by the ideological content of RWP parties, this study will examine the degree to which RWP party supporters are significantly less concerned about climate change when individuals are situated in comparable economic contexts. In contrast to prior research (Kulin et al., 2021; Huber, 2020; Duijndam & van Beukering, 2020), this paper will investigate how the influence of RWP parties varies among individuals across a diverse spectrum of regional and economic contexts. Accounting for regional and individual economic determinants, this paper assesses whether economic circumstances that have frequently been cited as a rationale for endorsing RWP parties, have in fact resulted in diminished climate concern. This is the first study that will disentangle to which extent the correlation between

supporting RWP parties and climate change concern is influenced by an individual’s economic context. Testing the structuralist theory through focused research of economic determinants allows this paper to draw more robust conclusions regarding the ideological impact of RWP compared to earlier research. The research will measure and compare the degree to which concerns are related to a wide range of regional and individual economic determinants that have not been considered in previous research. In doing so, this paper is also able to understand whether economically disadvantaged individuals are less concerned about climate change. Lastly, the research will also provide valuable insight into the extent to which aligning with RWP parties can be predicted by the economic circumstances of individuals.

3 Literature Review

So far, scholars that have aimed to examine the influence of RWP, as well as related populist values, consistently fall short of accounting for economic effects that are likely to influence why people vote RWP parties and the extent to which they are concerned about climate change. Using data from the 2015 British Election Study, Huber (2020) shows that individuals with high populist attitudes as well as individuals that vote for RWP parties are significantly more skeptical about climate change, however, besides income, the paper fails to incorporate any structural economic factors that have frequently been linked to a rise in RWP. Similarly, Kulin et. al (2021) show that individuals who hold nationalist values and vote for RWP parties are more likely to be skeptical about climate change. The authors construct the nationalist values from multiple survey questions including an individual’s stance towards the EU as well as their stance on the economic effect of migrants on the domestic economy. Yet, an individual’s perspective on the benefits of migration for the domestic economy, as well as their stance on the European Union, is likely to be conditioned on their economic circumstances. The research indicates that supporting RWP parties and holding nationalist and populist values appear to shape an individual’s perspective on climate change. However, structural economic conditions are likely to impede the causality of these claims.

On the other hand, research that assesses the influence of economic factors has primarily focused on a narrow set of determinants, such as GDP, income, and unemployment (Duijndam & van Beukering, 2020; Kenny, 2019; Scruggs & Benegal, 2012), neglecting other structural economic determinants that have been linked to the rise of RWP parties. Additionally, most of the research that assesses the impact of economic determinants on climate change concern typically does not incorporate the influence of RWP parties and consequently is unable to disentangle such influence from the broader economic effect (Kenny, 2019; Scruggs & Benegal, 2012). Using European survey data from 2008-2017, Duijndam and van Beukering (2020) are the first to explicitly examine the role of economic effects and the influence of RWP parties on climate change concern. In line with the structuralist theory, the authors find whenever individuals are unemployed or whenever the unemployment rate increases domestically, individuals are significantly less concerned about climate change. At the same time, the authors find that people are more concerned in countries with greater GDP per capita, providing partial evidence that individual- as well as national-level economic conditions might shape an individual’s relation towards climate change. In contrast to Lockwood (2018), the authors do not discover significant evidence that RWP parties play a role in shaping climate concern. However, their analysis only focuses on the impact of a country-level increases in the vote share of RWP parties on an individual’s climate concern. Yet, the insight of this analysis is fairly limited. As the impacts of climate change intensify, concern among a segment of society is likely to rise and offset aggregate effects of RWP parties.

In his theoretical contribution, Lockwood (2018) challenges the structural theory, as the author argues that socio-economically disadvantaged individuals often referred to as ‘left behind’ aren’t certainly more likely to be skeptical towards climate change in comparison to other groups. Additionally, the author argues that the constituency of RWP parties reach far wider than the ‘left behind’, as RWP parties have also resurged in north-west European countries despite greater worker protection and stronger welfare. However, the author acknowledges that a concrete understanding of the influence of economic effects and RWP requires more empirical and focused research (Lockwood, 2018).

Overall, studies examining why RWP party supporters tend to exhibit more climate skepticism and lower concern about climate change have provided limited understanding of the structural economic

and ideological mechanisms underlying this association. Apart from basic economic circumstances such as income, unemployment, and GDP, the literature has largely overlooked many structural economic determinants associated with endorsing RWP parties. The question of why supporters of RWP tend to be less concerned and more skeptic towards climate change remains unanswered.

4 Research Design & Data

To answer the research questions, the paper will deploy Causal Forests methods – an extension of Random Forests – to obtain the conditional average treatment effect of endorsing RWP on climate change concern for different values of the covariates. As political polarization of climate change is far more pronounced in Western than Eastern European countries (McCright et al. 2016), the effect of RWP on climate change concerns is likely to vary across regions. Addressing the heterogeneous treatment effects associated with RWP, the application of Causal Forests appears especially valuable to understand how the treatment effect varies across different regional, ideological, and economic subgroups of our data. Moreover, Causal Forests, being non-parametric, are advantageous over conventional regression techniques as they make fewer assumptions about the underlying data distribution and can capture complex non-linear relationships even in the presence of high-dimensional interactions among covariates and multi-level clustered data (Levi, 2020). This proves beneficial for two key reasons: firstly, due to the hierarchical structure of our data, encompassing country, regional, and individual levels; and secondly, because numerous variables, including political ideology and age, are known for their non-linear relationship with stances on climate change (Huber, 2020; Levi, 2020; Scruggs & Benegal, 2012).

We exploit data from the 8th and the 10th wave of the European Social Survey (ESS), a cross-national large-scale sample survey (ESS Round 10, 2020; ESS Round 8, 2016). The ESS provides data on the independent variable, i.e., alignment with RWP parties, and the dependent variable, i.e., climate change concern. Additionally, sociodemographic variables like age, education, and gender, along with several confounding variables such as trust in science, political ideology, national ideology, the respondent’s region of residence (NUTS2), the time spent using the internet as well as the time spent consuming political news, will be sourced from the same dataset. Individual-level economic data, including household income (absolute as well as relative to country), unemployment (and recent unemployment), union membership, and industry of employment (NACE 2.0), will also be extracted from the ESS.

Complementing individual economic data, regional and national economic determinants that previously have been linked to the rise of RWP will be incorporated. At the national level, the analysis will incorporate social mobility sourced from the Global Database on Intergenerational Mobility (Protzer, 2021). Data on the wage-inequality within and between each region as well as the net changes in social spending (Bergh & Kärnä, 2021) are obtained from Eurostat. At the regional level, unemployment, sectorial employment and wages, as well as net migration will also be derived from Eurostat. Lastly, we proxy regional-level exposure to globalization through trade exposure taken from Bez et al. (2023). The research will be conducted with a careful consideration of the limitations of such study. Particularly, due to the inherent limitations of the pooled cross-sectional data, the paper can only cautiously suggest a causal link between aligning with RWP parties and an individual’s climate change concern. The likelihood of reverse causality posing a threat to our inference appears minimal. Nonetheless, certain time-varying uncontrolled confounding factors, particularly an individual’s engagement with social media, could shape their stance on climate change as well as their probability to align with RWP parties. In contrast to previous research, this paper aims to address this by incorporating the amount of time spend consuming political news as well as the time spend online. To strengthen the ability to affirm stronger causal assertions, alternative sources of panel data will be assessed prior to the start of the research project.

5 Significance

Ambitious climate policy that aims to mitigate the detrimental effects of climate change, is at risk. To make stringent climate policies feasible, it is of vital importance to understand the mechanisms that are leading to the political backlash against environmental policies. The rise of RWP movements appears to be a particularly strong threat to the implementation of climate policy, as supporters of RWP parties are known to be less concerned and more sceptic about climate change (McCright et al. 2016). Given the limited empirical evidence demonstrating a causal relationship between RWP parties and climate skepticism (Lockwood, 2018), this paper seeks to investigate whether endorsing RWP parties influences an individual’s concern about climate change.

Unlike preceding studies, this paper will break new ground by undertaking an extensive empirical analysis of the structural theory, leading to robust conclusions regarding the influence of RWP parties on climate change concern. State-of-the art machine learning methods enable this research to assess how the impact of RWP parties varies among individuals across distinct regions, ideological convictions, and specific economic conditions. The results of this analysis yield valuable insights into the extent to which RWP party supporter are less concerned about climate change within a wide range of subgroups of our sample. Matching multiple sources of economic data to the survey data empowers this paper to assess and compare the relative influence of a wide range of regional and individual economic conditions that have been overlooked in previous research. Additionally, the analysis will yield valuable insight into the extent to which certain economic conditions are able to predict whether a person endorses RWP parties.

6 References

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